

06 — Corpora: theories, methods, and applications

Lexicology and Lexicography — **Course Website**

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Outline

1. Introduction to corpus linguistics (30 min)
2. Sketch Engine tutorial (25 min)
3. Practice using Sketch Engine (30 min)

Fundamentals of corpus linguistics

What is corpus linguistics about?

Corpus linguistics is a **research methodology** that focuses on the **systematic study of language** using large and diverse **collections of authentic texts**, known as **corpora**.

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What corpora have you heard of or used? (e.g. COCA, BNC, Google Books)

Goals and approach

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- From a *usage-based* perspective, **linguistic structure and knowledge emerge from the patterns** that speakers encounter in their experience with language.

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What is corpus linguistics good for?

What advantages might corpus linguistics offer over introspective methods? Consider:

- What kinds of questions can we answer with corpus data that we couldn't answer (well) otherwise?
- What are potential limitations or challenges?

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 - e.g. vocabulary lists based on corpus frequency; collocation dictionaries

Key concepts

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Examples

- **General:** BNC, COCA, Google Books — wide variety of text types
 - e.g. How does the frequency of *going to* vs *will* vary across different text types?
- **Specialised:** BNC 2014 Spoken, academic journal corpora, learner corpora — specific genres or domains
 - e.g. What collocations do learners use with *make* vs *do* in academic writing?

Annotation

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Metadata: data **about** language use on several levels:

- corpus
 - texts: author, text type, register, topic
 - ↳ paragraphs or utterances
 - ↳ running words (tokens): word class, lemmatisation
 - ↳ tokens: *walk*, *walks*, *walked*
 - ↳ type, lexeme, lemma: WALK ^v

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What might we discover by comparing the collocations of *pretty* vs *beautiful*?

Sketch Engine tutorial

<https://wuqui.github.io/SkEtut/>

Practice: using Sketch Engine
for lexicology

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- If time allows, briefly look at a **word sketch / collocation view** for each item to see typical lexical partners.

Task overview

Work in groups with **BNC 2014 Spoken**. There will be **three groups**, each working on a different set of lexical items but following the **same steps**. You have **about 20 minutes** for the corpus work and then **around 3 minutes per group** to report your findings.

During the work phase, each group should:

- explore basic **corpus information** for BNC 2014 Spoken, including which **text types** / metadata categories are available (e.g. age, gender, education)
- run at least one **simple concordance query**
- inspect **basic frequency** (and, if time, simple collocation/word sketch information)
- add notes directly to the **shared PowerPoint file** that you will use for your report

Task 1: Intensifiers — *really* vs *very*

Question: How are *really* and *very* used as intensifiers in spoken English?

Steps:

1. In Sketch Engine, select the corpus **BNC 2014 Spoken**.
2. Open the **corpus information** view and note down: approximate size, time period, what kinds of spoken data it contains, and which **text types** / metadata dimensions are available (e.g. age, gender, education).
3. Run a **simple concordance** search for lemma *really* and then for lemma *very* (one at a time) in BNC 2014 Spoken. Skim a few lines to see how they are used.
4. Use a **frequency or word list view** (or the frequency information in the concordance results) to compare how frequent *really* and *very* are overall.
5. Choose **one “text type” dimension** (as defined in Sketch Engine), such as age group, education level, or gender, where you **expect differences** between *really* and *very*. Use the **frequency by text type** view in Sketch Engine to compare how frequent each item is across those groups.
6. If time allows, have a quick look at a **word sketch / collocation view** for each item and see what typical collocates appear.

Task 2: Reporting verbs — *say* vs *tell*

Question: How are *say* and *tell* used to report speech in spoken English?

Steps:

1. In Sketch Engine, select **BNC 2014 Spoken** (same corpus as Task 1).
2. Look at the **corpus information** and briefly note size, period, main types of spoken interaction, and which **text types** / metadata dimensions are available (e.g. age, gender, education).
3. Run a **simple concordance** search for lemma *say* and then for lemma *tell* (one at a time). Skim several lines for each.
4. Use a **frequency / word list** or concordance frequency information to compare how frequent *say* and *tell* are in BNC 2014 Spoken overall.
5. Choose **one “text type” dimension** (e.g. age, education, gender) where you **expect differences** in how *say* and *tell* are used. Use the **frequency by text type** view in Sketch Engine to compare how frequent each verb is across those groups.
6. If time allows, inspect a **basic collocation / word sketch** view for *say* and *tell* to see what they typically co-occur with (e.g. pronouns, that-clauses).

Task 3: Discourse markers — *like* vs *you know*

Question: How are *like* and *you know* used as discourse markers in spoken English?

Steps:

1. In Sketch Engine, select **BNC 2014 Spoken**.
2. Use the **corpus information** to remind yourselves what kinds of spoken data are included (e.g. everyday conversations, interviews), and which **text types** / metadata dimensions you can use later (e.g. age, gender, education).
3. Run a **simple concordance** search for *like* and then for *you know* (you may have to filter out some non-discourse uses of *like* by reading the lines carefully).
4. Use a **frequency / word list** or frequency information from the concordance to compare how frequent *like* and *you know* are overall.
5. Choose **one "text type" dimension** (e.g. age, education, gender) where you **expect differences** in how *like* and *you know* are used. Use the **text type / metadata breakdown** in Sketch Engine to compare how frequent each item is across those groups.
6. If time allows, look at a **collocation / word sketch** view to see typical patterns (e.g. what comes before/after these items).

References

Stefanowitsch, Anatol. 2020. *Corpus Linguistics*. Berlin: Language Science Press.
<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.3735822>.